

EPISODE ONE

The premise

v3, 2026-08-28. Working title not settled.

Names are placeholders only. Alice, Bobby, Carla, Dan and Edward are there so nobody has to hold four unnamed men in their head. Fable invents the real ones next, and will deliberately not be told which of them did it.

Alice dies in her own home. It is recorded as an accident, so nobody investigates, and within a few weeks it is simply a sad thing that happened to somebody.

She had four close friends: **Bobby, Carla, Dan and Edward**. In the months before she died Alice had become frightened, because she had worked out that one of those four was planning to kill her. She hid what she had. She did not go to the police, partly because what she had was not quite proof, and mostly because taking it to them meant accusing somebody she loved. So she made an arrangement instead. If anything happened to her, all four of them would be sent a key.

After the funeral, the keys arrive in the post. All four of them go to the same place.

It is already empty.

So four people who loved Alice are left knowing one thing for certain: one of the other three got there first. They have nothing they can take to the police. What they have is each other, and the fact that between them they knew her better than anyone alive did. They start meeting. They start trying to work out which of them it is.

Carla gets close. She keeps it entirely to herself, because you do not say that out loud about a friend until you are certain.

She does not have to say it. **Bobby is the only person in that room who knows for certain that one of them is guilty and exactly which one**, and he has spent weeks sitting in those meetings watching three people hunt him. He does not need Carla to accuse him. He only needs to notice that she has stopped looking at the others.

A few days later Bobby disappears. His car is found near the coast, at a spot the whole city knows people go to when they want to end things. His phone is left on the seat. No body is ever recovered, which is normal there.

And Carla stops.

Because there are only two ways to read it. Either she was wrong about him, or she was right and she drove a man off a cliff. She cannot live inside the second one, so she chooses the first, and she lets it go. It never stops bothering her.

Months later a stranger begins talking to Carla. He knows things about Bobby's death that nobody has said out loud. He will not put any of it in writing. He says he will meet her and tell her the rest, and he names the place: the spot where the car was found.

She goes.

Carla falls onto the rocks, and her body washes up in Havenbay harbour a few days later. There is nothing about her injuries that a fall does not explain, so nobody thinks she was pushed and they assume she jumped. And everybody has a reason ready, because she had spent months blaming herself for the friend who went off the same cliff.

Three friends gone, one after another, and the city settles on grief. It happens.

Except that Dan and Edward each know something the police do not. One of the four emptied that cupboard. Each of them knows it was not him. Carla is dead and Carla was the one who worked hardest at it. **So it is Bobby, or it is the man sitting across the table.**

Nobody can do anything about Bobby. No body, a known spot, a closed file. Some officers privately think one of the two living friends did it. Some think Bobby was never in that water at all. Neither side can prove a thing and it has sat there ever since.

But you can suspect a dead man and still be frightened of a living one. **Dan is afraid of Edward. Edward is afraid of Dan.** And each of them is frightened enough to walk into a police station and say so.

Two men accusing each other of three deaths, neither able to account for where they were, is front page news. Ally's podcast picks it up a day later.

Bobby is alive. He is four hundred miles away under another name and he thinks it is finished, and he is not wrong to think so. He killed Alice, he removed the one person who was about to see it, he did it in a way that reads as grief, and he left two friends behind doing the rest of the work for him.

Ally comes to all of this afterwards. She prevents nothing, and she could not have. What her podcast does, slowly, is establish that the man everybody has spent months mourning was never harmed at all.

She does not do it alone, and she could not have. Her listeners do it. Small pieces from subscribers, some of them anonymous and some not. Somebody who kept a message Carla sent them and thought nothing of it at the time. And eventually a woman four hundred miles away who has been listening to a description of a man for six weeks and has slowly understood that she knows him, under a different name, and that he has been sitting across a table from her.

★ **And that is what it costs.** The moment Ally proves Bobby is alive, Dan and Edward stop being suspects and become the only two people on earth who could identify him.

They are named. They are findable. And for the first time since he walked away from that cliff, Bobby has a reason to come back.

What it is about

Carla was the best of the four at seeing what was in front of her, and it killed her. Dan and Edward are the two who were not. They were spared because they were not good enough, and neither of them will ever say that out loud to the other.

And they spent months each certain the other one was going to kill them. They were both wrong.

Then Ally proved it, and made it true.

Still open, so you know what you can change

- **The title.** *Five Keys After Midnight* is retired. Current suggestion is *The Friend They Mourned*.
- **Who these five actually are.** Not decided at all. Fable writes them next.
- **What Alice hid,** and how she came by it.
- **How long ago all of this happened,** and how long Ally's podcast runs for.
- **Which of Dan or Edward comes to Ally,** and whether either of them is anything to her already.
- **Where in Havenbay it sits,** including which stretch of coast.
- **How it ends.** Only that it should be honest about what it costs. They get their names back. They do not get their friendship back, and Carla was right all along and nobody ever told her.

Settled, and expensive to move: four friends rather than five · Alice's death recorded as an accident · the place already empty when they get there · Carla keeping her suspicion to herself · Bobby vanishing before Carla dies rather than after · the stranger who baits her back · her injuries explaining themselves · Bobby being untestable rather than cleared · Ally arriving after all of it · the listeners finding the pieces.